

**DEPARTMENT
PHILOSOPHY**

Clients must be made aware that public assistance is limited to 60 months to meet their family's needs and they must take personal responsibility to achieve self-sufficiency. This message, along with information on ways to achieve independence, direct support services, non-compliance penalties, and good cause reasons, is initially shared by Michigan Department of Health and Human Services (MDHHS) when the client applies for cash assistance. The Partnership. Accountability Training. Hope. (PATH) program requirements, education and training opportunities, and assessments will be covered by PATH when a mandatory PATH participant is referred at application.

**DEPARTMENT
POLICY****PATH Application
Eligibility Period**

Completion of the 10-day PATH application eligibility period (AEP) part of orientation which is an eligibility requirement for approval of the FIP application. PATH participants must complete all of the following in order for their FIP application to be approved:

- Begin the AEP by the last date to attend as indicated on the DHS-4785, PATH Appointment Notice.
- Complete PATH AEP requirements.
- Continue to participate in PATH after completion of the 10-day AEP.

Deny the FIP application if an applicant does not complete all of the above three components of the AEP.

Jobs and Self-Sufficiency Survey

At application, the registration support staff must provide clients with a DHS-619, Jobs and Self-Sufficiency Survey. For applications received from MI Bridges, the questions from the DHS-619 have been incorporated into the screens. Specialists must do all of the following:

- Review the survey or the PDF copy of the application from MI Bridges, and other information in the case record and Bridges

during the intake interview to make a preliminary barrier assessment to determine the client's readiness for PATH referral.

Note: Be alert to indicators that the client or family members suffer from undisclosed or undiagnosed disabilities. Some disabilities diminish the individual's ability to recognize or articulate his/her needs or limitations. Temporarily defer clients who need further screening or assessment.

- Identify and provide direct support services as needed. Child care and transportation barriers are common. MDHHS is responsible and must assist clients who present with child care or transportation barriers before requiring PATH attendance; see BEM 232 Direct Support Services.
- Open/edit the Family Self-Sufficiency Plan (FSSP) and enter strength and barrier information identified and addressed during the intake process.
- Temporarily defer an applicant with identified barriers until the barrier is removed.
- Temporarily defer an applicant who has identified barriers that require further assessment or verification before a decision about a lengthier deferral is made, such as clients with serious medical problems or disabilities or clients caring for a spouse or child with disabilities.

Note: Clients should not be referred to orientation and AEP until it is certain that barriers to participation such as lack of child care or transportation have been removed, possible reasons for deferral have been assessed and considered, and disabilities have been accommodated.

Work and Self-Sufficiency Rules

Use the DHS-1538, Work and Self-Sufficiency Rules, to explain all of the following to clients at FIP application for each episode of assistance:

- Direct support services opportunities, including transportation and child care required to attend AEP orientation.
- Work requirements and reasons why a person may be deferred from PATH and work requirements.

- Self-sufficiency requirements.
- Penalties for non-compliance, the triage, hearing processes and good cause.
- Earnings or activity reporting and verification requirements, including the semi-annual reporting requirement for families with earnings.
- Domestic violence.
- FIP is limited to a 60-month lifetime limit per individual; see BEM 234, FIP Time Limit.
- Prohibited use of FIP to purchase lottery tickets, alcohol, or tobacco. It is also prohibited for gambling, illegal activities, massage parlors, spas, tattoo shops, bail-bond agencies, adult entertainment, cruise ships or other nonessential items.

Ensure the client understands his/her responsibility to participate in employment-related activities including, but not limited to, calling before they are unable to attend a meeting or appointment and before they become noncompliant.

The DHS-1538 must be reviewed and signed by all of the following applicants and member adds:

- Adult members.
- Minor parent grantees.
- Deferred and potentially deferred adults.
- Ineligible grantees.

File the original signed copy of the DHS-1538, Work and Self-Sufficiency Rules, in the case record; a photocopy is given to the client at the in-person interview or is mailed to the client following a phone interview.

Timing of PATH Referral

Mandatory PATH clients are referred to PATH upon application for FIP, when a client's reason for deferral ends, or a member add is requested. Do not send any others to PATH at application, unless a deferred client volunteers to participate. All PATH referrals are sent by Bridges. Bridges will generate an automated PATH referral to the one-stop service centers' One Stop Management Information System (OSMIS), as well as generating an DHS-4785, PATH

Appointment Notice, which is sent to the participant, when the specialist does all of the following:

- Completes data collection.
- Eligibility determination/benefit calculation (EDBC) is completed for applicants.
- EDBC is completed and ongoing benefits are certified for member adds and ongoing active cases.

Note: Do not use the following manual processes:

- Call the one-stop service center to have them terminate a referral on OSMIS.
- Enter a new referral that was not included on the interface between Bridges and MIS.
- Manually generate a DHS-4785 when Bridges has indicated that it has created a referral to PATH and a corresponding DHS-4785.
- Manually enter denials prior to the 17th day after a PATH referral is sent. It is critical that both MDHHS and the PATH staff wait for interfaces to function. Manual entries on either side will cause a client to disconnect from both systems.

Clients Losing Deferral

When a client no longer qualifies for a deferral, Bridges sends a task/reminder to the specialist ten days before the end of the month the deferral ends. This task/reminder alerts the specialist to run eligibility and certify in order for the PATH referral and the DHS-4785 to be automatically generated by Bridges. Bridges sends the PATH referral and the DHS-4785 the first business day of the calendar month after the deferral ends.

Referrals Already Active on MIS

In most instances, OSMIS will accept a referral for a client who is already active on OSMIS. The new referral is accepted, and a flag is sent to the one-stop service center advising a new referral is pending. Clients are identified as active and attended PATH in Bridges. Activation of the new referral is handled by the one-stop service center.

Rejected Referrals

The following PATH referrals are rejected and need further action as indicated by a task/reminder or via email:

- Address mismatches. When Postal Soft in Bridges is not used to verify address accuracy, a rejection may occur. Check address using Postal Soft in Bridges and re-refer the client.
- SSN/Customer ID Mismatch. An email will be sent to the specialist of record with instructions.

Monitoring Pending PATH Referrals

The specialist can monitor PATH referral status in Bridges through Inquiry/DLEG referral history.

Bridges automatically denies FIP applicants still pending or creates a record of noncompliance when a member is added or client whose deferral is ending when attendance at PATH is not entered by the one-stop service center by the 17th day after the day the PATH referral is made. Bridges also automatically denies FIP when a client fails to continue to participate while the FIP application is pending. Clients can reapply for FIP at any time after their application is denied for failing to appear or participate with PATH.

PATH coordinators should monitor engagement using the QG report series.

FAST and FSSP Notice

Bridges issues a FAST FSSP notice (DHS-1535, FAST Referral Notice or DHS-1536, FAST Mandatory Notice) to all work eligible and non-work eligible individuals upon completion of the intake interview and after worker runs EDBC in Bridges; see BEM 228, Family Automated Screening Tool and Family Self-Sufficiency Plan.

PATH Appointment Notice and Attendance Requirements

Bridges will automatically issue a DHS-4785, PATH Program Appointment Notice, from Bridges at application, member add, or

when a client loses a deferral to schedule an appointment for each mandatory PATH participant. The DHS-4785 will be generated overnight and can be viewed the next day in Correspondence History.

In generating a PATH referral and the DHS-4785, Bridges will allow 6 days for the PATH referral to be processed through Central Print before requiring the client to attend PATH. The one-stop service centers have been advised not to serve clients who appear for AEP or PATH without a system-generated referral as client may not be eligible for PATH services. Bridges will include the date, time and location to appear for their PATH assignment on the automated DHS-4785.

When assigned, clients must engage in and comply with all PATH assignments while the FIP application is pending. PATH engagement is a condition of FIP eligibility. Failure by a client to participate fully in assigned activities while the FIP application is pending will result in denial of FIP benefits. Bridges automatically denies FIP benefits for noncompliance while the application is pending.

Bridges will not penalize Food Assistance when a client fails to attend PATH as a condition of eligibility when the noncompliant individual is not active FIP on the date of the noncompliance. Clients must be active FIP and FAP on the date of FIP noncompliance to apply a FIP penalty to the FAP case.

Bridges will generate an alert when active FIP recipients, including clients losing deferral or member adds do not attend PATH. See BEM 233A for further policy related to noncompliance with employment-related activities.

Note: Do not manually deny FIP or manually enter a noncompliance for failing to attend PATH. Wait for the Bridges interfaces to create the record. Task and reminders are sent to workers when Bridges takes action or receives an attendance through the interface process.

Extending the Last Date to Attend Orientation

Either MDHHS or the one-stop service center may extend the last day the client has to attend AEP/orientation when necessary. Extend this date directly on OSMIS before the 15th day passes. To extend the last date to attend PATH:

- Use applicant search to locate a client.
- Choose the welfare registration screen.

- Select work first program.
- Select welfare registration.
- Scroll down to last date to attend orientation.
- Extend the date.

LEGAL BASE**FIP**

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